

Establishing Long and Positional Cards

Beyond force: tricks from the length of a suit and from where the opponents' honors sit.



1 Three ways to establish

By force Equal cards: give up the higher honor. Seen already.

By length Play the suit until the opponents have none left.

By position Your honor wins if the opponents' honor is in the right place.

2 By length

When your side holds **more cards than the opponents** (7 is enough), the last ones become winners even if low. What counts: the **length** of the long hand and how the rest **split**.

Diagram showing a club suit: North has ♣ 762, West has ♣ 1085, East has ♣ J9, and South has ♣ AKQ43. A blue circle with 'N' and 'S' is between West and East. Text below: "A K Q, then the 4 and 3 are good: **5 tricks**".

Diagram showing a diamond suit: North has ♦ 109762, West has ♦ AQ, East has ♦ 8543, and South has ♦ 8543. A blue circle with 'N' and 'S' is between West and East. Text below: "two rounds: the honor. North has **3 tricks** established".

Long suits always produce tricks, even "ugly" ones.

3 Keep your entries

Established cards must be reachable. West leads the 10♥: to take 13 tricks South wins **with the ace or king**, not the jack.

Diagram showing a heart suit: North has ♠ 963, ♥ Q4, ♦ 52, ♣ A97642. West has ♠ J7, ♥ 109865, ♦ 1084, ♣ J53. East has ♠ Q1054, ♥ 732, ♦ QJ93, ♣ 108. South has ♠ AK82, ♥ AKJ, ♦ AK76, ♣ KQ. A blue circle with 'N', 'E', 'W', and 'S' is in the center.

1. K♥, then K♣ and Q♣.
2. J♥ to the Q♥: you're in dummy.
3. A♣ and the established clubs: a 3-2 split, 13 tricks.

4 By position: where their honor sits

Diagram showing a heart suit: North has ♥ AQ5, West has ♥ ?, East has ♥ ?, and South has ♥ 863. A blue circle with 'N', 'E', 'W', and 'S' is in the center. Text below: "**Finesse**: low toward the queen. Works if West has the king."

Diagram showing a heart suit: North has ♥ K85, West has ♥ ?, East has ♥ ?, and South has ♥ 763. A blue circle with 'N', 'E', 'W', and 'S' is in the center. Text below: "Low toward the lone king. Works if West has the ace."

Diagram showing a spade suit: North has ♠ A63, West has ♠ ?, East has ♠ ?, and South has ♠ QJ10. A blue circle with 'N', 'E', 'W', and 'S' is in the center. Text below: "Lead the queen: if West covers, J and 10 are promoted. Works if West has the king."

If their honor is in the wrong place nothing helps: but the try works about half the time.

5 Honor or low card?

Ask yourself whether you'd be glad to see your honor covered. If you gain nothing, don't lead it first.

Diagram showing a club suit: North has ♣ A543, South has ♣ Q72. Text below: "Leading the queen establishes nothing: the opponents hold the J, 10 and 9. Play **low toward the queen**, hoping East has the king."

6 On defense: cover an honor with an honor

Second hand: low on low, honor on honor.

Diagram showing a diamond suit: North has ♦ AQ94, West has ♦ K83, East has ♦ 1072, and South has ♦ J65. A blue circle with 'N', 'E', 'W', and 'S' is in the center.

If South leads the J, West covers with the K: East's 10 becomes a winner. If South leads the 5, West plays low.

7 The stopper

Diagram showing a spade suit: North has ♠ 87, West has ♠ 9432, East has ♠ QJ, and South has ♠ AK1065. A blue circle with 'N', 'E', 'W', and 'S' is in the center.

Cards that stop the opponents from taking every trick in a suit. East's queen and jack fall, but **West's 9 wins the fourth round**: one careless discard and the stopper is gone.

On defense: if dummy has a long suit and partner holds fewer cards in it than you, don't discard a single one.